

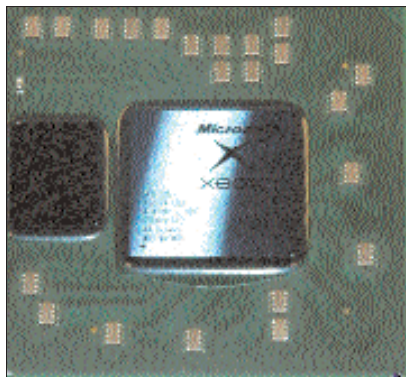
The Xenos part from ATI comprises of two cores, the traditional unit where the shaders lie and a daughter core, which is the smaller of the two and is comprised of 10MB of embedded high-speed memory along with some processing hardware. To understand this engineering feat we need to take a short detour and visit two places—one is the concept of embedding itself: in broad terms the shorter the path between a processing unit and any form of memory, the better it is for the system. Hence, you currently have 1 MB and 2 MB worth of L2 cache for processors even though the system itself might offer as much as 4 GB of memory. Embedding things is generally a good idea, thus. The second stop is the fast-approaching HDTV, and the whole HD-era/revolution/better-than-sliced-bread thing.

High-definition content is said to start at 720p resolution (1280x720, progressive or non-interlaced scan). 720p is incidentally the resolution that the Xbox 360 is happiest displaying at. The Xbox 360 requires the 10 MB of embedded memory to work on frame buffers at HDTV resolution. Think of a frame buffer as a canvas to paint on—the final image shot to the television screen, will come from this buffer. The 10 MB of eDRAM (embedded DRAM) is capable of storing up to a 4X anti-aliased image at 640x480 or a 1280x720 frame (720p) without anti-aliasing applied. This math applies to a single large frame, or canvas. The Xenos cuts up the frame into so-called tiles and instead of working on one very large canvas, it divides the final output into more manageable chunks. Each of these tiles can now easily fit into the 10 MB of eDRAM, even with 4X FSAA (full-screen anti-aliasing). Basically, your games will look pretty.

Playing It LIVE

The Xbox 360 builds on the success it enjoyed with the LIVE initiative of its predecessor. LIVE, in essence, is a whole bunch of services rolled into a uniform package. As a match-making service it offers each owner of the console a unique identity-based on his or her username of choice, and a display picture. This “Gamertag” displays a player’s “Gamerscore”, tracks all the games played, his or her reputation based on peer-feedback, and acts as an identifier to online friends. LIVE also collates a list of your online friends and messages from friends or challengers. You can also link your Gamertag to forum avatars, track your messages from a PC, send invites to a game via a computer while away from the console, and so on. In addition to text, LIVE also offers voice-chat during a gaming session.

This communication layer is just one aspect of the LIVE package. The system also offers the Xbox Live Marketplace which offers casual and arcade games (Xbox Live Arcade) for trial downloads and online purchases. You can also pay for additional content packs from game developers-



Seen here, the Xenos sitting next to its daughter eDRAM

these can take the form of wallpapers for the 360's interface, or themes, or icons for your Gamertag, and so on. The Marketplace also offers free content in the form of game trailers and game demos. It is fairly common to find a demo of an upcoming title to try out; we PC gamers might not consider these features too revolutionary but it is certainly a great addition to console gaming.

This diverse range of content is presented via a pleasant interface comprised of “blades”. Each blade is in essence a tab, which leads to a different menu:

- ❑ Xbox Live/Marketplace - Connects the user to Xbox Live. It also offers management options for the player's list of friends, messages, and Marketplace transactions.

- ❑ Games - Keeps track of played games and earned achievements. Also allows access to Xbox Live Arcade and downloaded game trailers and demos.

- ❑ Media - This is where one can manage media content and use the Media Extender functionality of the Xbox 360.

- ❑ System - Changes to the system, privacy, and security console settings are found here.

A shaky start

The Xbox 360, at least on paper, does a commendable job of balancing sundry tasks and offers a compelling gaming platform. Marry that to a collection of development tools which are perhaps the most mature and easy

to get into in the console space, and one can imagine the 360 doing much better than its predecessor this time around.

One of the main goals of Microsoft this round was to launch early and amass sufficient user base to compete effectively when the PlaySta-



The Xbox 360 can display a unified blade during gameplay. This blade allows one to send messages, check your score and play custom music



The Marketplace offers both free and paid content to Live users

tion 3 launches late this year. At this, the console has been largely unsuccessful. Production problems during the holiday season of 2005 curbed the units sold to a huge extent. Moreover, its performance in Japan is actually worse than its predecessor's already dismal showing. To date, Xbox 360 has shipped close to three million units worldwide and plans to sell around 10 million before the PS3 ships. Right now, it seems a difficult goal to achieve. Sony meanwhile, plans to ship a total of six million PS3 units by March of 2007. Some would call Sony's projection just as optimistic. While it remains to be seen which of the two consoles will win this round, one thing is certain—we consumers have never had it better-between these two and Nintendo's Wii, everybody wins. ■

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